(i) When an object is pushed, the atoms in our hand interact with the atoms in the object and this interaction is basically electromagnetic in nature.

(ii) When we stand on Earth's surface, the gravitational force on us acts downwards and the normal force acts upward to counter balance the gravitational force. What is the origin of this normal force?

It arises due to the electromagnetic interaction of atoms on the surface of the Earth with the atoms present in the feet of the person. Though, we are attracted by the gravitational force of the Earth, we stand on Earth only because of electromagnetic force of atoms.

(iii) When an object is moved on a surface, static friction resists the motion of the object. This static friction arises due to electromagnetic interaction between the atoms present in the object and atoms on the surface. Kinetic friction also has similar origin.

From these examples, it is clear that understanding electromagnetism is very essential to understand the universe in a holistic manner. The basic principles of electromagnetism are dealt with in volume 1 at XII standard physics. This unit deals with the behaviour and other related phenomena of charges at rest. This **branch of electricity which deals with stationary charges is called Electrostatics.**

1.1.1 Historical background of electric charges

Two millenniums ago, Greeks noticed that amber (a solid, translucent material formed from the resin of a fossilized tree) after rubbing with animal fur attracted small pieces of leaves and dust. The amber possessing this property is said to be 'charged'. It was initially thought that amber has this special property. Later people found that not only amber but even a glass rod rubbed with silk cloth, attracts pieces of papers. So glass rod also becomes 'charged' when rubbed with a suitable material.

Consider a charged rubber rod hanging from a thread as shown in Figure 1.1. Suppose another charged rubber rod is brought near the first rubber rod; the rods repel each other. Now if we bring a charged glass rod close to the charged rubber rod, they attract each other. At the same time, if a charged glass rod is brought near another charged glass rod, both the rods repel each other.

From these observations, the following inferences are made

(i) The charging of rubber rod and that of glass rod are different from one another.

(ii) The charged rubber rod repels another charged rubber rod, which implies that 'like charges repel each other'. We can also arrive at the same inference by observing that a charged glass rod repels another charged glass rod.

(iii) The charged rubber rod attracts the charged glass rod, implying that the charge in the glass rod is not the same kind of charge present in the rubber. Thus unlike charges attract each other.

Therefore, two kinds of charges exist in the universe. In the 18th century, Benjamin Franklin called one type of charge as positive (+) and another type of charge as negative (–). Based on Franklin's convention, rubber and amber rods are negatively charged while the glass rod is positively charged. **If the net charge is zero in the object, it is said to be electrically neutral.**

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